

80 Elijah

The prophet of fire who stood alone against Baal, then met God in a still small voice.

Elijah of Gilead burst onto the scene when Baal worship had become the religion of Ahab and Jezebel's court. He announced a drought, was fed by ravens and a foreign widow, and called down fire on Mount Carmel. Then, worn out and afraid, he asked God to let him die. God fed him, met him at Horeb, and sent him back to work. Scripture records no death for Elijah; he was taken up in a whirlwind. The prophets promised his return, and the New Testament sees it in John the Baptist and shows Elijah talking with Jesus at the transfiguration.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Eliyahu</i> , "my God is the LORD"
Home	"The Tishbite," of the inhabitants of Gilead (1 Kings 17:1)
When	Prophet in the northern kingdom, c. 860s–850s BC
Kings he faced	Ahab and Ahaziah; a letter to Jehoram of Judah
Key places	Cherith, Zarephath, Mount Carmel, Horeb, the Jordan
Key people	Ahab, Jezebel, the widow of Zarephath, Obadiah, Elisha
Appearance	"An hairy man," with a leather belt (2 Kings 1:8)
New Testament	Called Elias; often linked with John the Baptist

"And Elijah came unto all the people, and said, How long halt ye between two opinions? if the LORD be God, follow him: but if Baal, then follow him. And the people answered him not a word."

1 Kings 18:21, KJV

The life of Elijah

Dates are approximate (BC). Most events are undated and follow the text's order.

c. 860s BC	● Announces the drought Elijah tells Ahab there will be no dew or rain except at his word, then God sends him into hiding. <i>1 Kings 17:1</i>
During the drought	● Cherith and Zarephath Ravens feed him by the brook. Then a widow's flour and oil never run out, and her son is raised. <i>1 Kings 17:2-24</i>
Third year	● Mount Carmel and rain Baal's prophets cry all day unanswered; Elijah prays, and fire falls. Then a great rain ends the drought. <i>1 Kings 18:1-46</i>
Soon after	● Flight to Horeb Fleeing Jezebel, he asks to die. An angel feeds him, and at Horeb God speaks in a still small voice. <i>1 Kings 19:1-18</i>
On the way back	● Calls Elisha He throws his mantle over Elisha, who leaves his oxen to follow him. <i>1 Kings 19:19-21</i>
Later in Ahab's reign	● Confronts Ahab After Naboth's murder, Elijah meets Ahab in the stolen vineyard with a word of judgment. <i>1 Kings 21:17-29</i>
c. 852-850 BC	● Final acts He rebukes Ahaziah for consulting Baal-zebub. Then, across the Jordan, he is taken up by a whirlwind. <i>2 Kings 1:1-2:12</i>

Group notes

Key activities

Elijah's story has two sides: bold public victories and private exhaustion. Both are told honestly. 2 Chronicles 21:12–15 records a letter from Elijah to Jehoram of Judah; how this fits the timing of his departure is debated.

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- I Stood before a king.** He spoke God's word to Ahab plainly: "As the LORD God of Israel liveth, before whom I stand." *1 Kings 17:1*

 - 2 Lived by daily provision.** He drank from a brook and ate what ravens brought, then lived on a widow's handful of flour. *1 Kings 17:2–16*

 - 3 Prayed for a dead boy.** He carried the widow's son upstairs, stretched himself on him three times, and cried to God. The child revived. *1 Kings 17:17–24*

 - 4 Challenged a divided people.** On Carmel he asked, "How long halt ye between two opinions?" *1 Kings 18:21*

 - 5 Mocked Baal's silence.** At noon he taunted the prophets of Baal: perhaps their god was talking, travelling or asleep. *1 Kings 18:26–29*

 - 6 Rebuilt the LORD's altar.** He repaired the broken altar with twelve stones, one for each tribe, and prayed a short prayer. *1 Kings 18:30–38*

 - 7 Prayed for rain.** He bowed down with his face between his knees and sent his servant to look seven times. *1 Kings 18:42–44*

 - 8 Asked to die.** Under a juniper tree he said, "It is enough; now, O LORD, take away my life." *1 Kings 19:4*

 - 9 Heard the still small voice.** At Horeb God was not in the wind, the earthquake or the fire, but in "a still small voice." *1 Kings 19:11–13*

 - 10 Passed on the mantle.** He called Elisha and later asked what he could do for him before he was taken away. *1 Kings 19:19–21; 2 Kings 2:9–10*

 - II Confronted injustice.** He told Ahab that dogs would lick his blood where they had licked Naboth's. *1 Kings 21:17–24*

 - 12 Was taken up.** A chariot of fire and horses of fire parted him from Elisha, and he went up by a whirlwind into heaven. *2 Kings 2:11*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Elijah.

Old Testament

1 Kings 17:1 – 2 Kings 2:12	The main account of his ministry
2 Chronicles 21:12–15	His letter warns Jehoram of Judah
Malachi 4:5	"Behold, I will send you Elijah the prophet"
Echo: Exodus 34:28	Like Moses, forty days with God at Horeb

New Testament

Matthew 11:14; Luke 1:17	John the Baptist, "in the spirit and power of Elias"
John 1:21	Asked "Art thou Elias?" John answers, "I am not"
Matthew 17:1–4	With Moses at the transfiguration
Luke 4:25–26	Jesus recalls Elijah's visit to a foreign widow
Romans 11:2–5	The seven thousand who had not bowed to Baal
James 5:17–18	"A man subject to like passions as we are"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did God give Elijah under the juniper tree before he gave him any new instructions (1 Kings 19:5–8)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God spoke in a still small voice rather than in wind, earthquake or fire (1 Kings 19:11–13)?
3. *Apply:* Elijah crashed right after his greatest victory. When have you felt low after a high point?
4. *Apply:* Elijah thought he alone was faithful, but there were seven thousand (1 Kings 19:18). Whom could you reach out to this week?